CHAPTER FIVE

WARS

The Yom Kippur War—October 6, 1973

In the summer of 1972, my family and I returned to Israel after seven years of service abroad in two different countries. Upon my return, I realized that I had become unfamiliar with the office, and I felt like a fish out of water. I was appointed to a job that did not meet my expectations. It consisted mainly of "paper-pushing"—I was providing intelligence and administrative services from the "desk" at headquarters to the branches it was responsible for abroad. In late 1972, I informed the unit's commander that I was not ready to continue in this position and requested that I be offered another job, even in another unit. I was only thirty-three years old at the time, and I told myself that unless I was offered something interesting and challenging I would consider retiring from the Mossad. The agreement that was reached was that my name would be put forward for the summer 1973 discussions on job assignments, as a possible candidate for the role of head of the Mossad's Operations Directorate; until then, I would spend a few months in Kurdistan as the head of our mission there.

In mid-1973, I returned to Israel and was indeed appointed head of the Operations Directorate. Taking on this position meant that I was going from being in charge of certain issues in a single unit to being responsible for matters that were pertinent to the entire institution, inter alia, as the Mossad's liaison to the other agencies in the intelligence community. The new role also brought me closer, both physically and professionally, to the bureau of then-Mossad director Major General (res.) Zvi Zamir.